

GROWTH AND HARVEST

The adult tea plant is hardy and can withstand a wide range of weather conditions, but it is slow to grow from seed. Tea growers, therefore, take special care of their young plants while they wait for the seeds to sprout and mature.

FROM SEED OR CLONE

The tea plant is grown for its foliage rather than its flowers or fruit (seeds). The ultimate aim is to have abundant new growth as often as possible throughout the growing season to ensure a healthy harvest. There are varying opinions on how to produce new plants successfully. Artisan growers often cultivate plants from seed because they believe that the adult

plant will be stronger for having fought its way through the seed barrier and up through the ground. More often, however, tea is propagated from cuttings, which eventually grow into adult plants, called clonal plants. These are ready for harvest slightly sooner than seedlings, and their characteristics dependably represent those of the mother plant, so are a safer bet for many growers.

GROWING FROM SEED

It takes more than one year for a flower to seed. Flowers start to bud on the tea plant in summer, opening in early fall. The seeds fall when the weather turns colder (October-January) and are gathered from the ground soon after. In China, they are collected in late fall or early winter.

